

Version #	Date	Details of change	Page / slide no.

Stakeholder engagement and communication management

Learning objective:

10. Understand stakeholder engagement and communication management as the ability to work with people internally and externally to achieve intended outcomes.



10a) Understand the relationship
between stakeholder analysis,
influence and engagement.

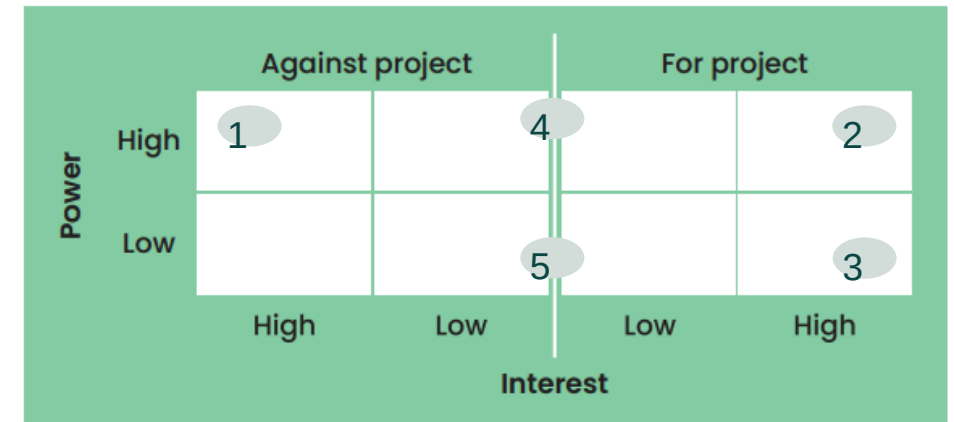
Stakeholder analysis

- Enables project managers to identify a project's key stakeholders, their interests in the project and the ways in which those interests affect project riskiness and viability.
- Supports stakeholder influence and engagement by identifying the views of stakeholders towards the project.
- Provides an understanding of who the project stakeholders are, their relationship to the project and their objectives which may impact the project.
- Enables the development of an appropriate engagement strategy appropriate for each stakeholder group.

Stakeholder analysis and communications

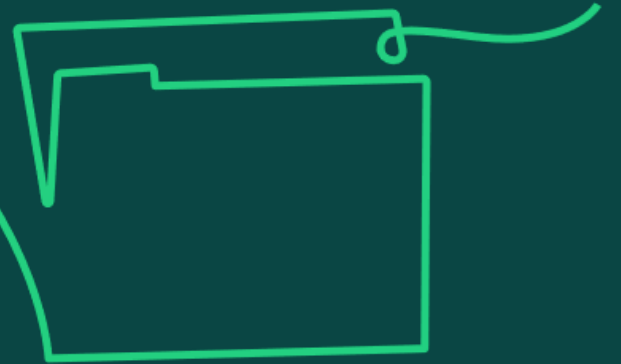
A stakeholder identified as:

- **High power, high interest and negative attitude** to the project may need intensive engagement from the project manager, and possibly the project sponsor or the senior management team, to avoid any risk they might pose.
- **High power, high interest and positive attitude** to the project may need regular engagement to maintain their support and commitment to the project so that they can continue to champion the project and support the removal of any obstacles or risks.
- **Low power, high interest and positive attitude** to the project may need regular engagement with sufficient information to keep them on side. Miscommunication or lack of communication can cause concerns within stakeholder groups which could lead to negativity towards the project, which could then cause challenges.
- **High power, low interest and a neutral attitude** to the project will likely need to have regular engagement of specific information, common with regulatory bodies such as the Health and Safety Executive, where providing specific information is a regulatory requirement and keeps the stakeholder group neutral towards the project.
- **Low power, low interest and a neutral attitude** to the project are likely to need little engagement. Provision of some information will be needed but this can be just a newsletter or similar. This will free up resources to focus on engagement with others with more power and interest.



Source: APM Body of Knowledge, 7th edition.

10b) Understand the relationship between stakeholder analysis and an effective communication management plan.



Stakeholder interests and their potential impact

- Stakeholders will have conflicting interests. Therefore, it is impossible to please everyone, but the aim should be to ensure the highest possible satisfaction among stakeholders is achieved.
- This can be done by assessing stakeholders' level of power or influence on the project and by understanding their level of interest in the project. A more in-depth assessment could also understand their attitude towards the project.
- By understanding these two / three parameters, the project manager and team can then decide how they should engage with the stakeholder and document this within a communication management plan.
- The frequency of communications should be tailored to the stakeholder group, as well as the type of media used, and the level of information and detail provided.

Stakeholder communication plan and engagement strategy

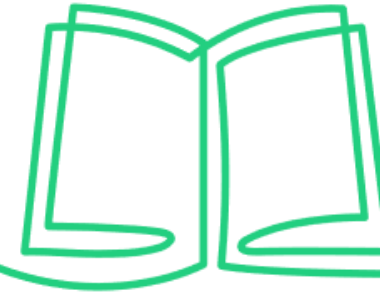
The stakeholder communication plan and engagement strategy should address:

- The particular message(s) to be communicated.
- The person best placed in the project organisation to carry out the communication.
- The most appropriate form of message, media or method that is likely to motivate / engage a stakeholder the most.
- The frequency of communications.
- The level of feedback that should be solicited or expected.
- The barriers that can be proactively identified and acted upon prior to communication taking place.
- The stakeholders which should / should not communicate with each other.



10c) Understand the benefits to a project of a communication plan.

Benefits of a communication plan



- Enhances stakeholder engagement.
 - Identifies target audience.
 - Tailors communications according to individual preferences, and power/interest/attitude.
 - Ensures relevant information is provided to stakeholders.
- Records the best method of communication for stakeholders, e.g. use of appropriate technology, opportunities for in person meetings, etc.
 - Avoids mis-understandings / conflict.
- Ensures a consistent approach to communication.
 - Assigns responsibilities for communications.
 - Provides a structured and systematic approach to communications.
 - Ensures project team understands requirements of communication.

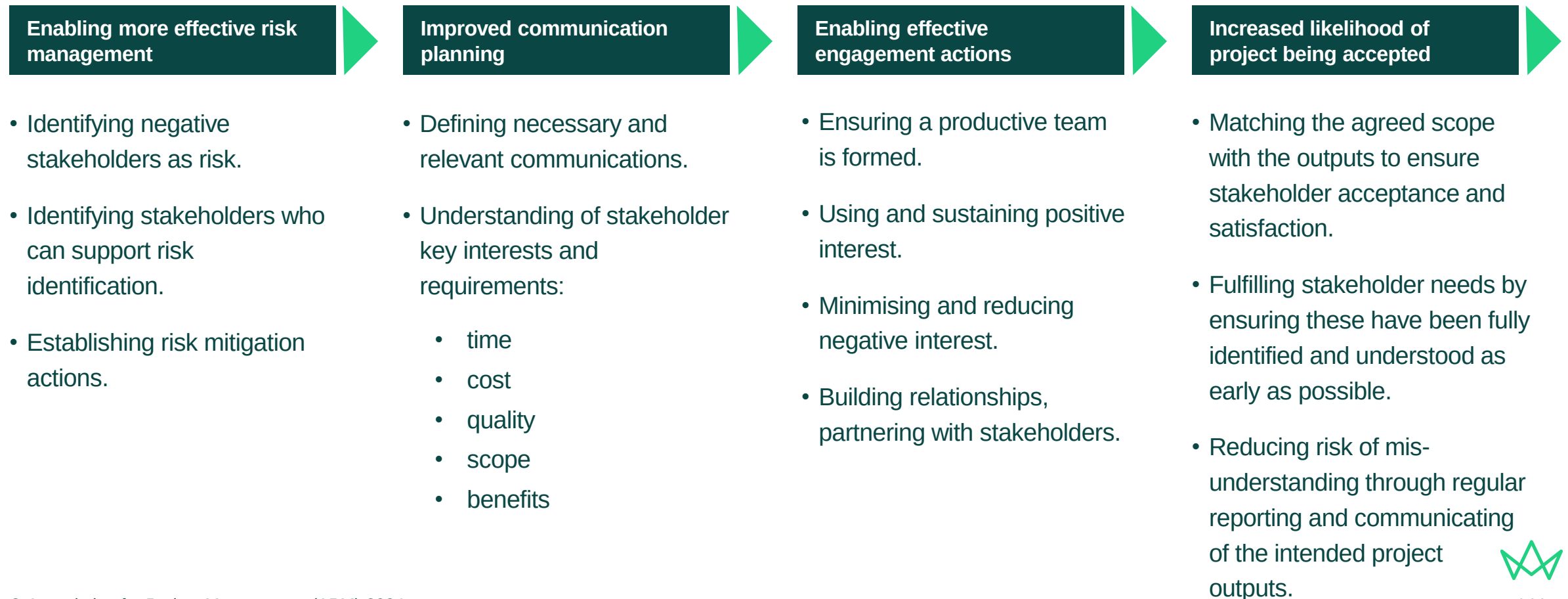
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10d) Understand the importance of managing stakeholder expectations to the success of the project.

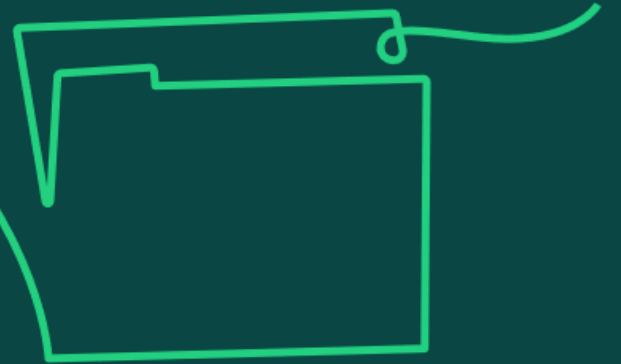


Managing stakeholder expectations

Carrying out an in-depth analysis of stakeholders consumes resources. To justify this consumption, the project manager must acknowledge the importance of managing stakeholder expectations and how that will influence overall success of the project, particularly in the following areas.



10e) Know the range of communication methods available and understand the importance of tailoring messaging to meet stakeholder requirements.



Communication methods and tailoring

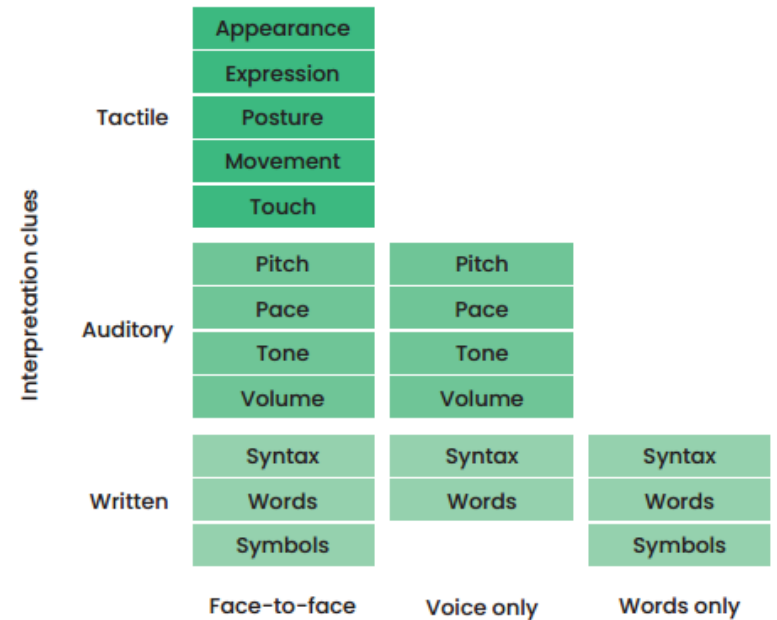
Communication methods

- Written using words / symbols.
- Electronic formats: be careful not to rely overly on one method, such as emails; the medium chosen must be appropriate.
- Verbal and face-to-face: consider the impact of body language (non-verbal signals).

The importance of tailoring messaging

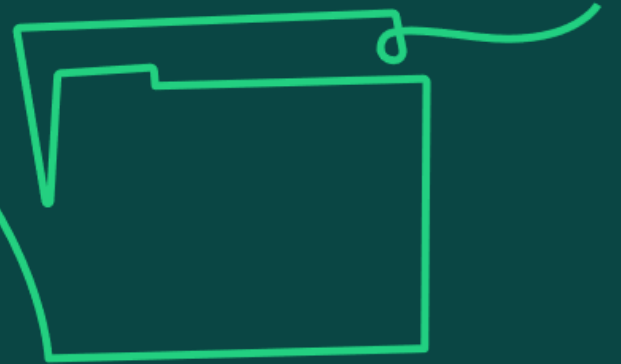
Effective communication needs to consider not only the message, but the medium used for communicating:

- It is important to understand who the target audience is, the intended impact and the risks / potential unintended impact of the approach.
- Cultural influences and language used should be considered.
- Organisations will have communication norms which should be considered.
- Communications should support timely governance procedures and approvals.



Source: *APM Body of Knowledge*, 7th edition.

10f) Know the factors which can positively or negatively affect communication.



Factors that affect communication

In groups identify 3 factors which could have a **NEGATIVE impact on communication**

State how you would resolve each of these?

Factors that affect communication

Physical location / time zones

- Project team members can be in different offices and locations around the world. The project manager can put systems in place to overcome the issues related to distance, such as virtual meetings.

Cultural diversity and language

- The impact of people's background culture and the organisational communication culture needs to be planned for. Project team members may not speak the same language or have the same cultural references, for example.

Skill and technical capabilities

- Having a variety of skills and capabilities is inevitable. Support mechanisms should be in place to assist those with less experience and knowledge. For example, technical jargon used on a project could be accompanied by information such as technical summaries and glossaries.

Physical environment

- A suitable, safe and comfortable environment with necessary facilities will enhance the team's experience. Distractions and noise can lead to a loss of focus and messages not being received correctly.

Body language

- Non-verbal signals can affect communication and sometimes can have a greater impact than the words themselves. It is important to be able to manage non-verbal signals so that these align with the message.

Personal circumstances and personality traits

- A person's interest and attitude, which may be related to their levels of workload or stress, can affect communication. People's preferences in terms of communication also come into play – whether they prefer written, virtual or in person communications, or through a detailed or a more strategic level approach.